



— MANAGER VOYAGE · MANAGER FOUNDATIONS · COURSE 1

You are a manager *now*.

Everything in the course, on paper: what changed, what a manager is, five ideas that hold up, what Vanderbilt will ask of you this year, who helps, the four jobs, how to read your assessment results, and what to learn next.

ABOUT 20 MINUTES ONLINE 19 PAGES · 5 TOPICS BEFORE: MANAGER COMPLIANCE COURSES
AFTER: THE MICRO MODULES RECORDED IN ORACLE LEARNING

— THE COURSE AT A GLANCE

Five topics, one *picture*.

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|-----------|--|----------------------|
| 01 | What changed, and what a manager is
The one change, three things that are new, what a manager is not, who helps you here. | PAGES 4 TO 5 |
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| 02 | Five ideas every good manager relies on
Priorities, clear expectations, psychological safety, purpose, the people work. Each with a moment to try. | PAGE 6 |
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| 03 | What Vanderbilt will ask you to do
The tasks of year one, when they show up, and your first calls: handle it, ask, route, or report. | PAGES 7 TO 8 |
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| 04 | The four jobs of a manager
Get the work done, take care of your people, make things better, connect your team. One page each, then your call. | PAGES 9 TO 14 |
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| 05 | Your assessment results
What the Manager Effectiveness Assessment asked, and your starting point. | PAGE 15 |
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Then a five-question check (4 of 5 finishes the course), your next seven days, a keep-learning list, and the wrap-up. Eight activities track progress; completion is recorded in Oracle Learning.

— THE MISSION

Define the great university of the 21st century, and *be* it.

THE VISION

Vanderbilt will define the great university of the 21st century and be it, and help reclaim the essential role of leading research universities in driving American prosperity.

HOW WE OPERATE

Uncommon speed, agility, and scale. Exceptional core operations are the fuel; bold initiatives and industry leadership are what they power.

AS WE GROW

Vanderbilt now works from more places: Nashville, San Francisco, West Palm Beach, New York City, and Chattanooga. As we grow, help your team understand how we operate, wherever they sit.

AS A MANAGER, YOUR FOCUS

- **ALIGN.**
Connect your team's work to the mission. Say the why.
- **PROGRESS.**
Move it forward with speed, agility, and scale: decide, unblock, finish.
- **STAY IN TOUCH WITH YOUR MANAGER.**
Strategy, projects, priorities, and anything else, so your team hears it from you first.

"Our mission is not small. We are scaling Mount Everest. Climbing Everest requires courage and commitment. But it promises the professional experience of a lifetime to all who sign on. And we will support one another at every step of the way." Chancellor Diermeier

Your job used to be your work. Now it is the team's work, and the *people*.

NEW 1

You decide.

What matters this week,
who does what, what waits.

NEW 2

You approve.

Timecards, time off,
expenses. Look before you
sign.

NEW 3

You are responsible for
people.

Fair treatment, a safe place
to speak up, a chance to
grow.

What a manager is not

Not the person who does
everyone's work

When you want to just do it
yourself, manage instead.

Not a friend first

Warm and fair. The team
needs a manager more
than another friend.

Not the police

Some things you send on,
the same day. Knowing
which is part of the job.

What a manager is

A manager is the person responsible for a team's work, and for the people who do it.

THREE QUESTIONS, EVERY WEEK

- Does everyone know what to do this week?
- Is anyone stuck, struggling, or waiting on me?
- What is coming that the team should hear from me first?

WHO HELPS YOU

- **Your manager:** stay in touch to stay aligned on strategy, projects, priorities, and anything else.
- **Your Engagement Consultant:** your go-to in PCB for HR issues, concerns, and support; the bigger people questions for your business unit.
- **Your HCM:** in most business units, for immediate HR issues: pay, hiring, performance, policy. First call when unsure.
- **The leave office:** time off for health and family. Same day. Never ask for a diagnosis.
- **EOA:** discrimination and harassment reports. Same day. You report; you do not investigate.

— TOPIC 2 · FIVE IDEAS

Five ideas every good manager *relies* on.

— 1 · SETTING PRIORITIES · THE BIG ROCKS METHOD

Put first things *first*.

WHAT IT IS

Picture a jar. Sand first (email, small requests) and the big rocks never fit. Big rocks first, and the sand settles around them. The big rocks are the few things that matter most.

AS A MANAGER

Monday, before email, name this week's three big rocks for the team. Put them on the calendar. Tell the team, so they can protect them too.

THE VALUE

Your calendar will fill itself, and the urgent is rarely the important. A team that knows this week's three things wastes less and finishes more.

START THIS WEEK

Write your three big rocks before you open your inbox. Tell your team.

— 2 · CLEAR EXPECTATIONS AND FEEDBACK · CLEAR IS KIND

Clear is kind. Unclear is *unkind*.

WHAT IT IS

Softening expectations and delaying feedback feels nice. It does the opposite: people spend weeks guessing what you meant, and the problem grows.

AS A MANAGER

Say what you expect, by when, and what good looks like. Out loud and in writing. Give feedback close to the moment, in private, with the specific thing you noticed.

THE VALUE

Fewer surprises at the deadline, fewer redo cycles, and a team that always knows where it stands.

START THIS WEEK

Say one thing you have been hinting at. Privately, plainly, kindly.

— 3 · PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

People only speak up when it is *safe* to.

WHAT IT IS

A team's shared belief that nobody is punished or embarrassed for a question, a mistake, or a disagreement. The best teams report more mistakes, not fewer: they catch them early. It is not about being nice. It is about making the truth cheap to tell.

AS A MANAGER

Three moments decide it: bad news, a question in front of others, a mistake. Thank first, solve second, learn the cause later. Never in front of the team. Admit your own mistakes out loud.

THE VALUE

You hear about problems while they are small. Late news is the most expensive kind.

START THIS WEEK

When someone reports a problem, thank them first. Then solve it.

— 4 · PURPOSE · START WITH WHY, TEAM FIRST

Explain the why. Take care of the people, and they take care of the *work*.

WHAT IT IS

People do their best work when they know why it matters, not just what to do. And a team that feels looked after protects the work and each other.

AS A MANAGER

Before a task or a change, say the why: what it is for, who it helps, what happens if it slips. When credit comes, pass it down. When blame comes, take it first.

THE VALUE

People who know the why make good decisions when you are not in the room. A team that trusts you tells you the truth and stays.

START THIS WEEK

Explain the why behind one thing you have been asking for.

— 5 · THE PEOPLE WORK · A MANAGER'S CORE RESPONSIBILITIES

The people work is the manager's *work*.

WHAT IT IS

The professional standard for people managers is consistent on one point: hiring, onboarding, expectations, feedback, performance, time and leave, and hard conversations are the manager's job, not PCB's.

AS A MANAGER

You run the 1:1, give the feedback, start the leave request the same day, open the requisition. Your HCM is your first call when you are unsure; your Engagement Consultant, for the bigger questions. The micro modules teach each task.

THE VALUE

Nothing waits for someone else to act. Your team gets answers from the person who knows them.

START THIS WEEK

Find out your HCM's and your Engagement Consultant's names, and how to reach them.

The ideas at work: three rules to keep

BAD NEWS

Thank first. Solve second.
Learn the cause later.
Never in front of the team.

EXPECTATIONS

Say what, by when, and
what good looks like. Out
loud and in writing.

CHANGE

The why before the what,
in your own words, before
the announcement.

Sources: the big rocks method (Stephen Covey); clear is kind (Brené Brown); psychological safety (Amy Edmondson); start with why, leaders eat last (Simon Sinek); the people manager standard (SHRM).

What Vanderbilt will ask you to do, and *when*.

Each task names its micro module in brackets. Each is a short how-to of its own.

EVERY WEEK

Run the team.

- A short 1:1 with each person (Running 1:1s)
- Look at work before it is due (Setting Expectations and Goals)
- Approve timecards and time off (Time and Attendance Approvals)
- Answer questions, or find who can (Oracle HCM for Managers)

EVERY MONTH OR QUARTER

Keep it on track.

- Approve expenses and purchases (Expense and Procurement Approvals)
- Set and check goals (Culture Amp)
- Give feedback while it is useful (Giving Feedback)
- Thank people for specific work (Giving Feedback)

A FEW TIMES A YEAR

The cycles.

- Performance reviews (Culture Amp)
- The compensation cycle (Compensation Cycle and Merit Basics)
- Hiring when a seat opens (Requisitions and Hiring)
- Onboarding a new hire (Onboarding a New Hire)
- Someone leaving (Offboarding and Transitions)

WHEN IT HAPPENS

Know the process. Move the same day.

- A leave request, including FMLA (FMLA and Leave)
- A flexible work request (Flexible Work Arrangements)
- An accommodation request (Reasonable Accommodations)
- A concern about a coworker or manager (Employee Relations Grounding)
- A performance concern (Performance Concerns and Progressive Discipline)
- Something you must report (EOA and Reporting Obligations)

Your first calls

Most manager moments come down to one question: handle it myself, ask my HCM, send it to the leave office, or report it to EOA?

Handle it

A normal manager task. Time off, a timecard question, a 1:1, feedback.

Ask my HCM first

There is a process. Pay, hiring, a performance concern, anything unsure.

Leave office, same day

Health or family time off. Never ask for a diagnosis.

EOA, same day

Discrimination, harassment, misconduct. You report; you do not investigate.

The first move, and what *never* to do.

A leave request (FMLA, medical, family)

First move. Thank them, adjust the work you can adjust this week, and send the request to the leave office the same day. Tell them you have done so and what happens next.

Never. Never ask for a diagnosis or medical detail. Never decide eligibility yourself. Never let the request sit while you “see how it goes.” Micro module: FMLA and Leave.

An employee relations concern (coworker conflict, a complaint about a manager)

First move. Listen, write down what was said and when, and call your HCM the same day to agree the next step. Do not promise an outcome.

Never. Never investigate a formal complaint yourself. Never discuss it with the team. Never punish someone for raising it. Micro module: Employee Relations Grounding.

Something you must report (discrimination, harassment, sexual misconduct, Title IX)

First move. Listen, thank them, write down what was said, and report it to Equal Opportunity and Access the same day. Tell the person you have done so.

Never. Never investigate, never ask the person to “work it out,” never wait for more evidence, never share it beyond EOA and your HCM. Micro module: EOA and Reporting Obligations.

A performance concern

First move. Have the clear conversation first: what you expected, what you saw, what changes by when. Write it down. If it does not change, call your HCM before you do anything formal.

Never. Never surprise someone at review time. Never improvise a warning or a plan. Never compare them to a colleague out loud. Micro module: Performance Concerns and Progressive Discipline.

A time-off request (vacation, a day off)

First move. Check coverage, say yes or no out loud with the reason, and approve it in Oracle.

Never. Never sit on it. Never make people feel they have to justify vacation. Micro module: Time and Attendance Approvals.

A timecard question (a 52-hour week, a missed punch)

First move. Ask about the week before you approve. Fix what needs fixing in Oracle. Vanderbilt trusts your signature, so look before you sign.

Never. Never approve without looking. Never let overtime become invisible. Micro module: Time and Attendance Approvals.

A flexible work request

First move. Check the flexible work policy, think about the role and the team, and answer within the week with the reason either way.

Never. Never say yes to one person and no to another for the same role without a reason you could say out loud. Micro module: Flexible Work Arrangements.

An accommodation request

First move. Say yes to the conversation, and send the request to EOA the same day; the accommodation process runs there.

Never. Never ask for a diagnosis. Never decide the accommodation yourself. Never treat the request as a performance issue. Micro module: Reasonable Accommodations.

A seat opens and you want to fill it

First move. Call your HCM first. Hiring starts with a requisition and an approval chain, and the job description may need updating.

Never. Never promise the job to anyone. Never interview without a structure. Micro module: Requisitions and Hiring.

You want to change someone's pay

First move. Ask your HCM first. Pay has a process and a cycle; what is possible depends on the calendar and the case.

Never. Never hint at a raise you cannot deliver. Micro module: Compensation Cycle and Merit Basics.

Someone resigns

First move. Thank them, ask about timing, and tell your HCM the same day. Then plan the handoff.

Never. Never take it personally in front of them. Never let knowledge walk out undocumented. Micro module: Offboarding and Transitions.

A new hire starts Monday

First move. Block their first day and first week now: who they meet, what they read, what they do first, and the 1:1 on day one.

Never. Never let day one be a laptop and silence. Micro module: Onboarding a New Hire.

A team member seems to be struggling (stress, mental health)

First move. Listen without diagnosing. Say what you can adjust. Point them to the Employee Assistance Program and, if leave comes up, the leave office.

Never. Never ask for a diagnosis. Never share it with the team. Never ignore a safety concern; if someone is at risk, call for help immediately. Micro module: FMLA and Leave.

An injury or a safety concern at work

First move. Get them care first. Report the injury the same day through the workplace injury process, and fix or flag the hazard.

Never. Never wait to report. Never send someone back to an unsafe task. Micro module: Employee Relations Grounding.

One picture that holds the whole *job*.

Nothing new to memorize: the same work, sorted. The Manager Effectiveness Assessment scores the same habits.

JOB 1

Get the work done.

Is the work getting done, and done well?

- Plan it (planning)
- Say it (clarifying)
- Check it (monitoring)
- Fix it (problem solving)

JOB 2

Take care of your people.

Are people growing, and staying?

- Listen and help (supporting)
- Grow them (developing)
- Thank them (recognizing)
- Trust them (empowering)

JOB 3

Make things better.

Is the team getting better at what it does?

- Explain the why (advocating change)
- Describe where you are going (envisioning)
- Let people try (encouraging innovation)
- Look back (collective learning)

JOB 4

Connect your team to the rest of Vanderbilt.

Does the team get what it needs from outside?

- Know the people (networking)
- Watch for what is coming (external monitoring)
- Speak up for your team (representing)

THE HABIT TO STOP

Doing the work yourself. When you are tempted to just do it, that is the moment to manage instead.

THE ONE THING TO ROUTE

Anything that sounds like leave goes to the leave office the same day. You adjust the load; they decide eligibility.

Reading your Manager Effectiveness Assessment *results*.

Taken before this course, and again six months after. Fourteen questions on how often you do these habits. Results by email: a score out of 70 and a band. Nobody passes or fails.

Developing, under 35

The fundamentals are not yet habits. That is normal in year one, and it is exactly what this program is for. Start with jobs 1 and 2: the 1:1, clear expectations, and specific feedback. Everything else builds on those.

Strong, 35 to 55

Solid but uneven. Some habits are already yours; others happen when you remember. The fastest gain is the job where your answers were lowest: make its habits weekly, on the calendar, so they stop depending on memory.

Advanced, 56 and above

The fundamentals happen without prompting, which is rarer than it sounds. The step up is reach: jobs 3 and 4, shaping how work gets prioritized beyond your own team, and building a team that learns without you in the room.

Which questions belong to which job

JOB 1

Get the work done.

- **Q11** Plan it (mapped out action steps and resources before a complex project)
- **Q2** Say it (told each person what success looks like, in specific terms)
- **Q3** Check it (reviewed progress early enough to correct before the deadline)
- **Q1** Fix it (found the root cause of a team problem and put a fix in place)

JOB 2

Take care of your people.

- **Q6** Listen and help (asked about workload or pressure before they raised it)
- **Q4** Grow them (gave specific feedback they could act on that week)
- **Q5** Thank them (recognized a contribution where peers could see it)
- **Q7** Trust them (let someone choose their own method once the outcome was agreed)

JOB 3

Make things better.

- **Q13** Describe where you are going (a clear, inspiring picture of the coming year)
- **Q12** Let people try (encouraged suggestions to improve how we work)
- **Q10** Look back (ran a review after significant work so the team could apply it)
- Explain the why is taught here and not scored on the assessment.

JOB 4

Connect your team.

- **Q14** Know the people (kept up relationships in other departments that help the team)
- **Q8** Watch for what is coming (brought information from outside the unit that changed priorities)
- **Q9** Speak up for your team (represented the team to a decision-maker outside the unit)

Your next seven days

TODAY

Take your first micro module
They come in your order,
starting with the job your
results pointed to.

THIS WEEK

Practice one habit
The one your results
pointed to. Do it once, on
purpose, and notice what
happened.

IN SIX MONTHS

Take the assessment again
Compare the band with the
one you started with.

TELL YOUR MANAGER

"I just finished the first Manager Foundations course. The habit I am practicing this week is [habit]. Ask me about it on [date]."

What to take *next*.

Ten courses in Oracle Learning, in order, and ten things from outside. Micro modules first. Then one item a month, on the job your results pointed to. Links are live in the PDF; in Oracle Learning you can also search by title.

Ten courses in Oracle Learning, in order

1 · ORACLE LEARNING [New Manager Foundations](#)

The whole first-year job in one course: expectations, delegation, feedback, and the shift from doing to managing.

2 · ORACLE LEARNING [Leading at VU - Compliance and Supervisory Fundamentals](#)

What Vanderbilt requires of a supervisor: the policies and duties behind module 3.

3 · ORACLE LEARNING [A Manager's Guide to Conducting Effective One-on-One Meetings](#)

How to run the weekly 1:1 so it is worth both people's time.

4 · ORACLE LEARNING [How to Manage Your Attention and Your Priorities](#)

The big rocks idea, applied to a manager's calendar and inbox.

5 · ORACLE LEARNING [Communicating with Clarity as a Manager](#)

Clear is kind, as a set of communication habits for managers.

6 · ORACLE LEARNING [How to Give Feedback People Can Actually Use](#)

Feedback people can act on: specific, timely, kind.

7 · ORACLE LEARNING [How to Manage Difficult Conversations](#)

How to hold the conversation you have been putting off.

8 · ORACLE LEARNING [Building Team Trust as a Manager](#)

Trust as something a manager builds on purpose, week by week.

9 · ORACLE LEARNING [Performance Management Foundations for Managers](#)

Goals, check-ins, and reviews as one cycle instead of one event.

10 · ORACLE LEARNING [Leading Your Team through Change](#)

Leading your team through a change you did not choose.

Outside Vanderbilt: podcasts, videos, and a guide

PODCAST [Manager Tools Basics](#)

The core casts: one-on-ones, feedback, coaching, delegation. Start with the one-on-ones episodes.

PODCAST [Succeeding as a first-time manager](#)

Three new managers on the surprises of the first year.

PODCAST [Is it safe to speak up at work?](#)

Psychological safety across creative teams, astronauts, and athletes.

VIDEO [Feedback in three parts: situation, behavior, impact](#)

The simplest feedback structure there is, in a few minutes.

VIDEO [The big rocks method, in two minutes](#)

The jar, the rocks, and the sand.

VIDEO [Psychological safety, from the researcher who named it](#)

Why the best teams report more mistakes.

VIDEO [Why good leaders make you feel safe](#)

The circle of safety, in one story.

VIDEO

Managing your boss

Your manager is the first person your team needs you connected to.

VIDEO

Delegation and priorities: the urgent and important grid

What to do yourself, what to delegate, what to drop.

GUIDE

Manager guides: one-on-ones, feedback, coaching with GROW

Free, practical guides a large company built for its own new managers.

Vanderbilt University · People, Culture and Belonging · Futures Learning Hub. Manager Voyage, Manager Foundations, Course 1: You Are a Manager Now. This guide mirrors the online course at the time it was generated; the online course is the current version. Questions about a situation: your HCM first, your Engagement Consultant for the bigger ones.